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Impact of COVID-19 crisis, global transformation approaches and emerging organisational adaptations: Towards a restructured evolutionary perspective

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1. Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic transforms our world drastically. It is now recognised as an unprecedented situation of a global crisis that accelerates the transition to the next phase of globalisation and the fourth industrial revolution (Altman, 2020; Bonilla-Molina, 2020; Steiner & Gurría, 2020). It touches upon and rearranges all the dimensions of our socio-economic and political reality. This exogenous health crisis leads the global socio-economic system in the next steps of profound structural transformations. It effectively paves the way for new and endogenously created socio-economic mutations. It leads to global social unrest and uncertainty, international recessionary pressures, declining global incomes, and vertical rise in unemployment and poverty in a variety of "traditional" industries (United Nations, 2020a, p. 19). In this context, it seems imperative to reorganise and enrich the theoretical tools at our disposal so that we can more fully interpret and predict these transformations. In other words, considering the COVID-19 global crisis, this chapter aims to explore the ever-changing, value-transforming global socio-economic context in terms of organisational analysis (Thrassou et al., 2019). It focuses on the following questions:

- What are the overall effects of the COVID-19 crisis on the global socio-economic system?
- What is the impact of the COVID-19 crisis on the already existing dynamics of the evolution of globalisation? Does this crisis accelerate or slow down, strengthen or hinder existing developments?
- What are the primary features for organisational adaptation at all spatial and sectoral levels, and what should we do from now on to mitigate adverse effects and enhance the positive outlook?

2. Methodology and structure

This contribution is conceptual, having as aim to examine the field from a generic and critical perspective. By setting broad questions that result from the current COVID-19 pandemic, we venture to explore fundamental and general trends examined in today's literature, which we approach in a semi-systematic way to arrive at a repositioned theoretical framework (Snyder, 2019). Concerning the specific content of this study, we think that a new evolutionary framework is necessary to the extent that we need to comprehensively understand how to treat, both in theoretical and practical terms, the current COVID-19 health and socio-economic crisis.

In this sense, this contribution attempts, initially, an elliptical presentation and diagnosis of the symptoms of the "disease" of the current COVID-19 crisis on the global socio-economic system, based on the existing theoretical equipment of today's economics and management science on the subject. It then presents specific theoretical perspectives on how we can understand and "treat" this "disease." Finally, it aims to counter-propose theoretical guidelines for creating a new generation of "diagnoses" and "therapeutics" for such symptoms from an evolutionary perspective.

In section 3, we highlight some of the critical impacts of the COVID-19 crisis on the global socio-economic system, following recent literature and reports from international organisations. In section 4, we analyse theoretical approaches and research platforms that interpret how the global socio-economic system evolves

and transforms at the beginning of the 21st century. Finally, section 5 synthesises the previous information and theoretical orientation to form the basis for a new and enriched theoretical perspective, and section 6 offers final remarks.

3. A brief outlook of the socio-economic crisis caused by COVID-19

Around the end of 2019, a group of patients with "atypical pneumonia" of unknown aetiology appeared in Wuhan, a city in China, temporarily referred to as "SARS-CoV-2" and today as "COVID-19" (Poon & Peiris, 2020). As of January 30, 2020, when the World Health Organization declared this disease a public health emergency of international concern, a multitude of developments are unfolding globally. From the moment several governments started to take precautionary measures to prevent the virus' transmission, such as lock-downs, social distancing, border closures, and human tracing, an unprecedented economic shock happened (Kang et al., 2020). In these extraordinary conditions for our economic and social system, digital integration now seems imperative, already causing radical changes in the way of life and our broader way of work and socialisation (Kuc-Czarnecka, 2020).

What is though the significance of these developments? Matthewman and Huppatz (2020) argue that this pandemic crisis is a gateway between one world and the next. In a similar vein, the World Health Organisation's Director-General has expressed the view that we have entered an irreversible reality in which there can be "no return to normal" (WHO Director-General, 2020). During the end of 2020, at the macrolevel of the global socio-economic system, most analyses point to a still uncertain "shape" and curve of the global recession (Gregory et al., 2020). The World Trade Organisation has even predicted that the pandemic crisis will overcome in most indices the corresponding financial crisis of 2008-2009 (Azevêdo, 2020). The International Monetary Fund, for its part, has, within a few months, adjusted at least twice its forecast for the global recession (IMF, 2020), while the World Bank has presented a plethora of estimates, the most positive of which have predicted a global recession of at least 4% (World Bank, 2020).

At the same time, the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD, 2020) forecasted the amount of investment loss for 2021 at 30-40%, while the World Economic Forum (2020a) has calculated that world trade will fall by up to 30%. The latter dimension seems hugely worrying for the immediate future of the world economy. The United Nations report (2020) that drafts a new global humanitarian plan foresees that the international economy will soon be facing with the rise of extreme poverty in many vulnerable and least developed countries on the planet (despite the progress of the last forty years of globalisation). The possible outbreak of famines in impoverished regions due to the profound disruption of global supply chains is another concern noted by this UN report.

This unfavourable picture of the world economy is also reflected in unemployment. The International Labour Organisation (ILO, 2020b) reports that working hours losses in the second quarter of 2020 will reach 14% worldwide, a number equivalent to around 400 million jobs. In a related study, the ILO (2020a) examines how working from home will affect the global economy. Only 18% of workers live in countries that have the infrastructure to enable them to work from home effectively. Also, only one in four jobs is compatible with remote working in developed countries and only one in six worldwide. The future of work concerns a growing number of scholars and policy centres. Accordingly, a scientific and technical research report of the European Union (Montalto et al., 2020) finds that those who work in the cultural and creative sectors are

mostly self-employed, having no other source of income and sick insurance. This fact increases the need to protect them from inequalities that COVID-19 will create in the near and long-term future.

Reading the recent report of the World Economic Forum (2020b) on the future and predictions for the working environment of 2025, it becomes clear that the epidemic has exacerbated existing inequalities that will continue to rise due to the ongoing spread of technology. All vulnerable groups of the working population, such as the unskilled, the long-term unemployed, the new entrants to the labour market, women, workers in temporary rather than well-paid jobs, those employed in the non-formal labour market without insurance cover, are the most affected ones by COVID-19. At the same time, in this explosive macroeconomic and macrosocial global context, old geopolitical and geoeconomic tensions remain and, to some extent, proliferate, especially in times when global governance seems multipolarised (Vlados & Chatzinikolaou, 2020). A typical example is that the EU's relations with China have deteriorated while remaining quite problematic with the US; for instance, in a survey of the European Parliament's department for external relations, 48% of Europeans have declared that their view of China has worsened after the epidemic (Gaub & Boswinkel, 2020). Simultaneously, international organisations in terms of G7 and G20 seem until now generally unprepared and hesitant to deal with this profound crisis. Such a development shows that at the level of the dominant geoeconomic and geopolitical forces, a lack of effective coordination at the level of global governance mechanisms gives rise to escalated confrontations (Larionova & Kirton, 2020).

In addition to the overall effects of the pandemic, at different industries and clusters of economic activity (capturing disturbances in mesoeconomic terms) a variety of already profound reversals and reclassifications can be identified. A typical example is the 5% drop in energy demand for 2020, 18% in energy investment and, consequently, 7% in energy-related CO2 emissions (International Energy Agency, 2020). This development is also related to a 50-60% drop in passengers travelling with civil aviation in 2020 compared to 2019 (International Civil Aviation Organization, 2020). The prospects of many industries, such as tourism and travel (but also infrastructure, catering and media, broadcasting and the sports industry, and many others), appear now nebulous for the foreseeable future, creating a chain reaction of adverse effects on related industries and entire production systems at international level (United Nations, 2020b).

Simultaneously, other industries seem to gain even more attention and to increase their effectiveness. For example, e-commerce retail sales recorded a 30% increase in April 2020 compared to 2019 in the EU27, as opposed to total retail sales that decreased by 17.9% (OECD, 2020). Similarly, the changes that have taken place within a year in the education sector are rapid. In a joint survey by UNESCO, UNICEF, and World Bank (UNESCO et al., 2020) a sample study found that most countries worldwide have taken at least one measure in 2020 to support those at risk of not having access to distance learning. However, three out of ten lower-income countries did not take any action.

At the regional level, the situation is equally worrying as well. As the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations reports (FAO, 2020), rural areas are less likely to adapt efficiently to this crisis, as of the 734 million people living in extreme poverty before COVID-19, 80% work in such areas and particularly in agriculture. These areas have difficult access to sanitation and health services, education, internet, social protection, and public infrastructure. It seems that less developed business ecosystems will experience a decline in their overall returns and not just in the impoverished corners of the planet. According to Epifanova et al. (2020), addressing COVID-19 requires the creation of innovative regional enterprise ecosystems, which make

small and medium-sized enterprises sustainable and resilient in times of crisis (Vlados, Katimertzopoulos, et al., 2019; Koronis & Ponis, 2018).

At the same time, at the microlevel of the economy, developments show that a radical adjustment of business models has already begun, regardless of industry or specific location. According to a survey with several business leaders by the World Economic Forum (2020b), more than 80% responded that they have already taken steps to speed up the digitisation of working processes. They have also expanded remote work procedures at approximately 80%, as well as automation up to 50%. On top of that, one of the modern challenges in this rapidly changing reality is that working from home has created mental health problems, with managers of many companies now facing a growing lack of trust and dedication of their employees (Parker et al., 2020).

Therefore, we see a rapid change of all conditions due to the current pandemic, in all social and economic activities. Negative macroeconomic trends have already been strongly manifested as a direct consequence of COVID-19, accompanied by the emergence of significant macrosocial problems. New forms of social exclusion, inequality, and poverty (simultaneously, in material and intangible terms) manifest themselves in the halting of the pace of development of many world's industries and regions. Many structural weaknesses of less-developed localities worldwide become deeper and cause significant pressures into increasing the resilience and adaptability of all socio-economic organisations at the microeconomic level. In other words, the challenges brought about by the current crisis caused by the COVID-19 pandemic seem that they concern without exception all socio-economic organisations, of all sizes and sectoral focus at the global level.

What tools do we have available today in the arsenal of social sciences to determine how the global system will change after this severe crisis? In the next section, a review of significant relevant theoretical approaches is attempted. The goal is to interpret this global transformation that takes place in the first quarter of the 21st century, on multiple levels and from an evolutionary perspective.

4. Approaches to the mutations of the global socio-economic system

Someone could argue that Adam Smith and the Classical economists were the first to analyse the evolutionary and historical change of the capitalist system. For Karl Marx, the economic system is the structural base and society is the overarching superstructure. According to Marx and Engels (1848), the constant revolutionary readjustments in the means of production determine the history of humanity, in all production and social relations. In the age of capitalism, there is an increasingly fast continuous development of technology and labour, restructuring of production, incessant shocks that take place and rearrange social conditions, eternal uncertainty, and mobility.

A great point of reference in understanding the dynamics of capitalist development is also the work of Schumpeter. In "Capitalism, socialism and democracy," Schumpeter (1942) suggests that long-term waves emerge that incorporate the dynamics of the capitalist process. Each of these waves contains and assimilates the reactions of a "business revolution," defined through the results of innovation. According to Schumpeter (1928), innovation means economic evolution and unstoppable change. Innovation, as a revolutionary act, is a function of production which leads to industrial expansion and general development of society. Increased specialisation and improved infrastructure are inevitable with this expansion, whose profound features and characteristics are in constant motion and readjustment. In this process, "creative destruction" also takes

place as a process in which outdated technologies, ageing industries, and "reassured" businesses gradually decline. At the same time, "modern" technologies, new sectors of economic activity and innovative enterprises appear (Schumpeter, 1942). In today's crisis conditions of COVID-19, Schumpeter's conceptualisation can offer useful insight since it can explain how existing industries head towards destruction, whereas new forms of socio-economic efficiency in the near and the long-term future take shape.

Several years have passed since Smith, Marx and Schumpeter introduced valid theorisations on capitalism, with the question that concerned them in some way to remain unchanged until these days: that is, how all individuals and socio-economic formations change throughout time (Andersen, 2009; Boulding, 1981; Dopfer, 2006; Vlados, 2019b)? The most common answer given by many economists, particularly in the context of evolutionary economics, is that the crisis process itself is the main springboard for constant change (Nelson & Winter, 1982). Furthermore, what do we mean by "constant change"? Is it possible for something to change and remain stable at the same time? Indeed, the only constant force that we are able as individuals to grasp, by our nature, according to the philosopher Heraclitus, is that of dialectic change (Williams, 1989). Well, through a long course of complex dialectic changes, the global economy entered the so-called phase of globalisation, identified to have started at around the 1980s (Levitt, 1983; Michalet, 1976). Also, some scholars place the initiation of globalisation as early as the late 19th – early 20th century ("first" globalisation), when the interconnection of world economies and societies multiplied notably, and the economic frontiers "opened" for the first time (O'Rourke & Williamson, 2002). With a comprehensive and aptly noted definition, Giddens (1990) argues that globalisation links distant localities so that distant events shape local happenings and vice versa.

Over the previous decades, several scholars rushed to suggest a predetermined and universal path for globalisation, towards a supposedly absolute predominance of Western civilisation worldwide. According to Ohmae (1985), the US, Europe and Japan formed a Triad power with universal strategy, ideological and market dominance, while Thurow (1992) did not have a very differentiated perception by suggesting the definitive establishment of a "triadic" world. From a convergent perspective, Fukuyama (1992) supported the idea that humanity was in the early 1990s facing an "end of history," and an "endpoint of mankind's ideological evolution" and "final form of human government." However, these static and ultimately simplified interpretations of reality are not confirmed today. The current crisis and restructuring of globalisation undoubtedly highlight a dynamically repositioned multipolarity between the different leading powers. They also show a continuous reproduction of heterogeneity and transfer of the centre of gravity, in institutional and functional terms, of the global socio-economic system (Laudicina & Peterson, 2016; Pieterse, 2018; Vlados, 2020). At the same time, the theoretical approaches available nowadays to the phenomenon of continuous global transformation reveal aspects that seem to be firmly oriented towards harnessing the spirit of evolutionary economic thinking.

According to the neo-Schumpeterian contribution of C. Perez (1983), long-term Kondratieff-type waves appear into the global socio-economic system, which changes radically and irreversibly as a whole within a range of 50 to 60 years (Kondratieff & Stolper, 1935). The upward trend (upswing) of a long wave starts when complementarity between social and institutional innovation is present, always emerging after the peak of the previous wave. The new "techno-economic paradigm brings an unprecedented growth in infrastructure, leading to catching the potential growth limits, heading towards the next "paradigm." Within the new

techno-economic paradigm, all production units and corresponding economic activities tend to integrate with differentiated efficiency (called generally as "optimal or ideal form of productive organisation"). For Perez, socio-institutional change is a parallel force. The stable growth period is always the combined result of the underlying techno-economic paradigm and socio-institutional change (see Figure 1).

[Figure 1 about here]

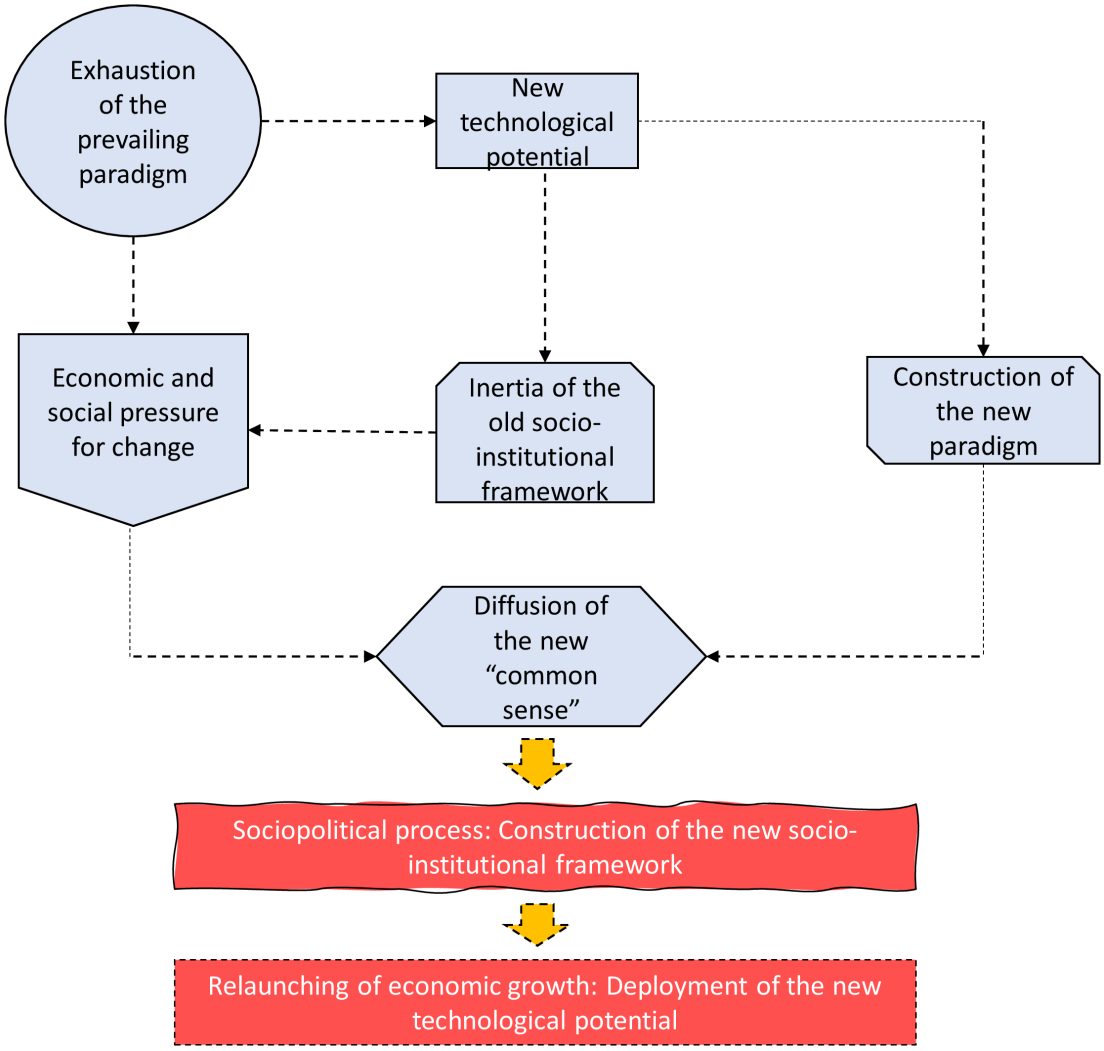


Figure 1: Techno-economic paradigm and socio-institutional change. Adjustment from Perez (2004)

According to Perez, the cohesion of the system depends on the type and space-time contour of long waves. The techno-economic paradigm, which is subject to constant change and renewal after every approximately fifty years, combines with a corresponding institutional framework, the change of which is slower due to the relative inertia of institutions. When there is a mismatch between economic and institutional development, lasting about 20-30 years (long wave's downswing), a "good match" follows that lasts about 20-30 years (upswing). In line with this approach, today, after the fifth Kondratieff wave of information technology (initiated at around 1990), some analysts predict the emergence of the sixth wave (Grinin & Korotayev, 2020),

where medical, additive, nano, information, and cognitive technologies will play a crucial development role. Complementing Perez's approach, our world today seems to be in the downswing phase, where there is a change in the techno-economic paradigm. However, corresponding social and institutional arrangements that will "legitimise" these innovations do not appear yet to be present (Raffaelli & Glynn, 2015). One possible criticism of the approach of Perez and long waves is that they go into macroeconomic and macrosocial phenomena rather than more specific organisational dimensions and procedures.

The fourth industrial revolution approach, which became famous following the introductory contribution by K. Schwab (2016) and the "Industry 4.0" term introduced by a paper of the German government (BMBF-Internetredaktion, 2016), is critical nowadays. According to the fourth industrial revolution terminology, our world is facing a rapid technological change, which transforms our social and labour relations profoundly. Schwab (2016) suggests that humanity's response to this emerging challenge must be comprehensive and multifaceted, including both private actors and universities and civil society. This challenge is the ongoing digital revolution in which there is a fusion of technologies that blurs the boundaries between the natural-biological and the digital world (from a historical perspective, the first industrial revolution concerns the mechanisation of production through the steam engine, the second the use of electricity for mass production, and the third the use of information technology to create automated processes).

However, the digital transformation that many governments see nowadays as the optimal growth strategy, after the contributions and diffusion of the fourth industrial revolution terminology, is to some extent unattainable, especially in less developed socio-economic systems. For example, according to Modiba and Kekwaletswe (2020), in sub-Saharan Africa and other countries with a population living in rural areas, there is limited technological accessibility. Although the authors see a trend towards digitisation (in sub-Saharan Africa, 43% of adults already have a bank account, compared with 34% in 2014), they think that technological, organisational, and environmental issues precede digital transformation.

From a mostly business-oriented point of view, a relatively recent approach that deserves mention is "chaotics" by Kotler and Caslione (2009). This perspective manages to combine the influence of the drastically changing internal and external organisational environment in the "new era" that is profoundly different from the previous, traditional one (see Figure 2).

[Figure 2 about here]

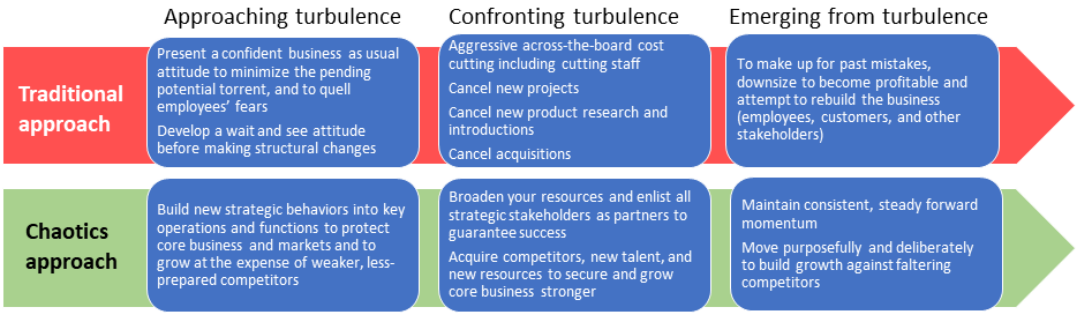


Figure 2: The traditional versus the chaotics approach. Adjustment from Kotler and Caslione (2009)

The authors note that our world, already from the last decade, has entered a state of chaos, and no traditional instrument and theory of organisational strategy and survival can be adequate. In the traditional perspective, the exit from the crisis follows a logic of downsizing and rebuilding the business (limiting the size for a superficial increase in profitability). In the chaotic method, any organisation must maintain a continuous and stable forward dynamic to create the conditions to dominate and grow against faltering competitors.

5. Towards a restructured theoretical perspective for understanding better the COVID-19 crisis

We think that both in the theoretical direction of the "fourth industrial revolution" and in the chaotic approach of Kotler and Caslione, there are points of inter-fertilisation that could help understand better the current crisis. Vlados et al. (2018) suggest a broader concept by also arguing that conventional and traditional approaches to economics and management are usually one-sided and simplified and do not focus sufficiently on the system's dynamics. They also argue that on the issue posed by innovation nowadays that economics, for several years already, has been progressively moving towards an integrated, systemic and evolutionary perspective (Arena & Lazaric, 2003).

This stream of thought progressively rejects the conceptual barriers of conventional neoclassical and Keynesian traditions, suggesting the global dimension of the phenomenon of innovation dynamics (Maurice & Sorge, 2000). In this direction, according to Nelson et al. (2018), we are still a long way from a persuasive "evolutionary macroeconomics" integrated into the Keynesian perspective of growth, where demand grows at the same rate as supply. The authors also note that the neoclassical perspective has treated economics as a problem of moving equilibrium between economic actors that behave as "optimal" profit-maximisers, while evolutionary economists use Schumpeter's creative destruction to describe economic development. However, these facts do not mean that economics does not seem "reluctant" to incorporate into its analysis the dimension of what the capitalist firm is and how it "thinks." There are still barriers in "bridging" economics and administrative sciences to which the study of innovation can provide a new and required evolutionary theoretical framework (Helfat, 2018; Vlados & Katimertzopoulos, 2019).

To begin with, a comprehensive approach to any crisis starts from the perception of organised activity as "Chaosmos," in the sense of the constant synthesis between chaos (complete disorder) and cosmos (fixed order). In this way, following the interpretation of Castoriadis (1993), the concept of chaos is recovering nowadays, reconnecting with the ancient Greek meaning of emptiness, abyss and infinity, in which a new world always emerges. Accordingly, an attempt to view the crisis in continuous and unifying terms, at the same time at macro, meso, and micro level has significant interpretative depth:

> Vlados (2017, pp. 25–26): "*Everything shows that, through the crisis, the 'new globalisation' is trying to emerge and take shape, with significant liquidity to this day, with a particularly challenging 'childbirth,' with the future structural outline still unclear, and in intense socio-economic and political upheavals and shocks articulated and intertwined now on a planetary level. […] today, the overcoming of crisis and the restructuring of the global system, that is, the*

insertion into a trajectory of a new and stable model of development, requires a leap of innovation aligned and implemented at all levels. Behind the necessity of this 'innovative transcendence' arises inevitably the problem of designing requisite new methodologies and mechanisms of change management, which will enable and make possible this transition."

This paragraph reflects the main argument of this chapter. As all the evolutionary approaches to the crisis show, our world now seems to be at a critical developmental juncture: either we are heading to a new future of prosperity and expanded social inclusion, or we will regress developmentally to various directions of our economic and social reality. In the approach of the "new globalisation," Vlados (2017) adds that the very way we define the crisis now needs additional analytical treatment and clarification. As the current pandemic crisis shows, no emerging situation can have any coincidental character and impact, nor could our world ever return to any previous normality; on the contrary, we are heading inevitably towards profound structural changes and re-positionings, which have their roots many decades earlier (Kindleberger, 1986). Through a structural understanding, the dealing with the current crisis is not a mechanistic attempt to adapt to a previous regime but an organic process that nurtures a new balance through a series of chain reactions and systemic adjustments. Moreover, the previous phase of globalisation, like the one that follows, based itself evolutionary on specific spatiotemporal processes and, more specifically, on the different forms of innovation and organisation of enterprises and the construction of international accumulation and regulation regimes (Vlados, 2019c).

Today, in the emerging global socio-economic system, the dimension of innovation must be the number one development priority. Some authors focus there, considering that today's innovative dimensions will play a vital role in the future. Torda (2020) analyses the fact that within only a few weeks, several higher education courses were reconstructed, suggesting the need to adapt as quickly as possible to innovative changes that may have significant long-term benefits. Heinonen and Strandvik (2020), categorising innovations resulting from the impact of COVID-19, they argue that these create opportunities for rapid business development and managerial rethinking as today's crisis forces organisations to explore business strategies beyond their usual. Also, according to Seetharaman (2020), several firms restructure their business models entirely following the crisis of COVID-19.

This effort to strengthen the innovative potential of each socio-economic organisation, cross-sectorally and globally, must succeed as quickly and effectively as possible. This innovation in emerging crisis conditions requires a systematic strategic repositioning effort, continuous technological modernisation, and upgrading of management mechanisms, always through a matched and integrated process of effective change management (By et al., 2011; Vlados, Deniozos, & Chatzinikolaou, 2018). From a generic perspective, the established system of the global economy from 1980 to date seems to be in a phase of maturation and destabilisation in structural terms (see Figure 3).

[Figure 3 about here]

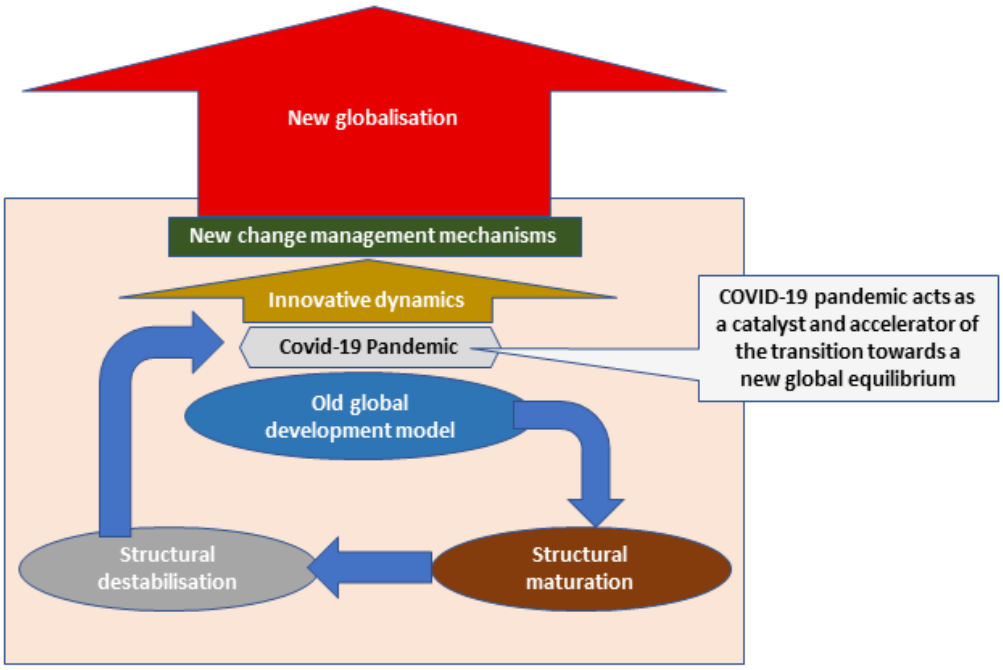


Figure 3: COVID-19, an accelerator towards a "new globalisation"

The current crisis of COVID-19 pandemic triggers a transformation far more profound than any change in the conjunctural and coincidental fall and decline of the various indicators of the global economic activity. Today, everything shows that we are entering a new phase of searching for a global development model, for which the current health and socio-economic crisis seems to act as a catalyst and accelerator of evolutions, creating new conditions in articulating the required new innovative dynamics and change management mechanisms at a national, local, and global level.

6. Conclusions and final remarks: Theoretical rearrangement and dialectic connection between the global crisis of COVID-19 and the multiple organisational transformations

Overall, this chapter has contributed to the understanding that the advent of a sufficiently stabilising "new globalisation" requires the re-conception of strengthening and cultivation of innovation and the change management mechanisms that will allow us to manage the new emerging global reality efficiently. The preceding analysis allows us to put forward the following conclusions:

I. The COVID-19 crisis has a direct and profound structural impact on the global socio-economic system. As the various studies of international organisations presented in this article show, we are facing an unprecedented shock to the world economy and society. We cannot yet predict the magnitude of the global recession. It seems that it will move to the highest levels, while the possible downward disruption of leading industries of yesterday's international economy might lead to multiplier and domino effects. In these circumstances, no "injections" of liquidity can cure mass unemployment, which already affects too many traditional industries, exacerbates poverty and inequality, and overall geopolitical stability. The way out of the crisis seems to require a comprehensive understanding of the necessary transformation (digital, strategic, tactical, and func-

tional) at all levels and a repositioned organisational adaptation with a rejection of superficial and ultimately "un-adaptive" ideologies and mentality, which will probably manifest themselves even more firmly in the coming years as an angry "resistance to change". For example, it should come as no surprise that nowadays a "neo-Luddist movement" (McKay, 2020) will undoubtedly have a negative impact on the necessary organisational adaptation to overcome the current crisis.

II. Everything shows that the COVID-19 crisis is not just a cyclical variation in the "quantities" of global capitalism, nor will the world return to a previous state. The crisis we are experiencing today repositions "qualitatively" global capitalism by accelerating its evolutionary trajectory. Thereby, it acts as a catalyst only for the structural transformations that have been nascent in recent years, especially since the 2008 crisis (Andreou et al., 2017). Consequently, approaches that interpret international economy in comparative static terms are necessarily insufficient (Krugman & Obstfeld, 1991; Reinert, 2011); on the contrary, those theoretical orientations that discuss how to transcend the incumbent evolutionary "Paradigm" of today's socio-economic sciences seem up to date (Kuhn, 1962).

III. Considering the current crisis of COVID-19, we must also focus on a critical neo-Schumpeterian dimension. Since innovation necessarily carries within the "winds of change," in the Schumpeterian form of creative destruction, a necessary repositioned perspective argues that organisational adaptation always includes the dual evolutionary system of both innovation and respective change management (Vlados, 2019a; Vlados, Chatzinikolaou, et al., 2019). According to Vlados (2019a), change management always arises because of the continuous dialectic synthesis between strategy, technology, and management. In this context, a socio-economic organisation must produce a new vision and transform its strategy; to make even more efficient use of tools and know-how in terms of technology; to manage even better the available and scarce resources; to effectively innovate on this synthesis and, finally, to successfully assimilate this process of change and to restart, for a new systematic cycle of change management.

In a "Veblenian" sense (Veblen, 1898), institutions also are "living spaces" that adapt to their environment. They are evolving socio-economic "organisms" that shape their external and internal environment simultaneously. Today's drastic change in the external environment reorganises the map of opportunities and threats; therefore, it requires a repositioning of the perception of all socio-economic organisations of their strengths and weaknesses. In addition to the above, it appears that the comparative strengths that seem to be of increasing importance nowadays are adaptability, the "de-materialisation" of the production process, safety, accuracy, and containment of costs.

By extension, we also need a new understanding of how we perceive economic policy, both at the national and international level. Simply stimulating active demand in macroeconomic terms and financial support for businesses does not seem enough. At the public policy level, we also need mechanisms to enhance primarily the ability of socio-economic organisations to develop and adapt (Peneder, 2017; Vlados & Chatzinikolaou, 2019). A faster and efficient adaptation to the emerging conditions is ultimately the crucial issue for our world to enter a new stabilising development trajectory.

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